

a huge change in the country. In places where copper was used earlier, it is mostly fibre network today. Most of the houses have fibre coming to their PCs. From the perspective of technology pervasiveness, times have changed majorly and there is a huge opportunity.

"With broadband roll-out, I think there is a major opportunity in Tier II and Tier III cities because new cables are being laid there. The new large deployments are happening in these areas. But hiring in this regard will be majorly happening in metro cities. Typically, 50 per cent of the business happens in Delhi and Mumbai in terms of ownership and engineering. Bengaluru is a strong place for the engineering options, especially in product development space. But as I said earlier, optoelectronics engineers will have the primary focus in R&D and lesser in the field jobs."

Optoelectronics engineers can work in two kinds of setups: a new business and an ongoing operations and management business. New businesses involving large project deployments are running in Tier III cities and beyond, while management and operations is taking place in Tier I cities.

Specifically, in telecom space, there are three areas where an optoelectronics engineers can fit in—product development, deployment and project management.

Sinha adds, "If you wish to be known as a pioneer, product R&D is the segment for you. That is where you can grow in terms of sustained business growth, but there are not many opportunities in India in this segment. Opportunities are more in network management, where you can grow and sustain for a longer period of time. The large project deployment space will be ideal to start with if you harbour an aspirational value. However, opportunities are limited here as these companies will want not just fresh graduates but people with experience to do the deployments."

Education needs to gear up

It's high time that educational institutions recognised the need of producing

specialised talent.

Panicker adds, "A lot of scope exists for improvement in terms of what is being provided and what is the need of the market. In colleges, these technologies are taught as part of general engineering. If you talk in terms of management, operations, project management and deployment, that's where the talent needs to be groomed, as this is the need of the market today. There is certainly a limitation there and curriculum makers need to address that need. Educational institutes are certainly not able to meet the requirements in the market place. Topics like operations and project management cover much wider spectrum than just a few technology terms."

Indian Institute of Technology-Delhi, University of Kerala and University of Calcutta are the premier institutes/universities that offer courses in optoelectronics engineering.

Hands-on experience

Hands-on experience is important to succeed in this field. Sinha says, "If I was a recruiter who had to choose between an electronics engineer with three years of experience in link fibre and a core optoelectronics engineer, I would go for the experienced resource."

Pay package

Typically, for a fresher, the pay package depends on the company policy. For R&D kind of jobs, candidates with masters or doctorate degrees are preferred. Their annual pay package may begin from around Rs 500,000 and go up depending on the job profile offered and, of course, technical knowledge of the candidate. For operations and project management roles, the pay package may vary from Rs 400,000 to 500,000. But if you compare the professionals in these two streams over a period of time, you will find R&D professionals making better progress than professionals in operations and project management. ●

The author is an assistant editor at EFY

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